EDUARD VAN DER MERWE

Ph.D. Candidate in Economics

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RESEARCH FIELDS

Development Economics, Economics of Culture and Religion, Applied Microeconomics

EDUCATION

- Ph.D., Economics, Rice University, USA (Expected) May 2027
- M.A., Economics, Rice University, USA 2025
- M.Com. [M.S. Equivalent], Econometrics, *Cum Laude*, University of Pretoria, South Africa 2021
- B.Com. (Hons) [4-Year U.S. B.S. Equivalent], Econometrics, *Cum Laude*, University of Pretoria, South Africa 2019
- Diploma in Emerging Markets and Country Risk Analysis, Fordham University, USA 2019
- B.Com., Econometrics, *Cum Laude*, University of Pretoria, South Africa 2018

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Articles

- "Religious Discrimination and Othering in the U.S. After October 7th: A Data Overview" (with Elaine Howard Ecklund & Kerby Goff). *Religions*, 2025, 16(12), 1552.
- "Climate Change and Child Malnutrition: A Nigerian Perspective" (with Matthew Clance & Eleni Yitbarek). *Food Policy*, 2022, 113, 102281.

Other

- "Book Review: When God Stops Fighting by Mark Juergensmeyer" (with Rachel C. Schneider). *Review of Religious Research*, 2024, 67(1), 158–159.

WORKING PAPERS

- **Job Market Paper**: "Preaching Against the Choir: Religious Leaders and Reproductive Norms in Kenya." 2026.
  Abstract: Religion shapes individuals' beliefs and behavior, but whether and how religious leaders can change social norms remains unclear. I study this in the context of family planning in Meru County, Kenya, using primary data from reproductive-age women. A central challenge to identification is that community behavior, scripture, and the stance of religious leaders are entangled in observed choices. Using a randomized vignette experiment that independently varies these forces, I disentangle them and identify the weight women place on each in a discrete-choice model with social interactions. I show that religious leaders influence women's decisions through two distinct channels. First, they directly shift women's utility. Their support for family planning increases women's willingness to adopt it, and this effect is larger than the corresponding effect of opposition. Second, religious leaders alter how women respond to the behavior of other women in their community. When a leader takes an explicit position, women place less weight on others' behavior. As a result, religious messages have their largest effects when they run counter to prevailing community behavior. I corroborate the experimental findings at scale using difference-in-differences estimates from a faith-based family-planning program, showing that program effects are largest in places where religious leaders are more trusted.
- "Heritage of Hunger: Ethnicity, Resource Allocation, and Child Poverty." 2026. Submitted to the *Journal of Economic Behavior & Organization*.
- "Americans' Moral Boundaries regarding Antisemitic and Islamophobic Speech" (with Kerby Goff & Elaine Howard Ecklund). 2026.
- "Government Religious Preference and Intrastate Conflict" (with Carolyn Chisadza & Matthew Clance). *Economic Research Southern Africa Working Paper Series*, 2021, No. 867.

WORK IN PROGRESS

- "Unequal Gains: The Changing Landscape of Global Individual Poverty" (with Rossella Calvi, Tanmay Devi, & Yunjie Xie)
- "Collective Action for Climate Resilience" (with Aanchal Bagga, Tanmay Devi, & Yunjie Xie)
- "Religion, Poverty, and Conflict: How Beneficial Is It to Adhere to the State's Religion?" (with Matthew Clance)
- "Understanding Refugee Poverty" (with Theresa Beltramo, Rossella Calvi, Giacomo De Giorgi, & Ibrahima Sarr)

FELLOWSHIPS, GRANTS, AND AWARDS

- Department of Economics, Rice University, Graduate Student Fellowship 2021 – 2027
- Society for the Scientific Study of Religion, Student Research Grant 2026

- Social Sciences Research Institute, Rice University, Dissertation Research Improvement Grant 2026
- Wagoner Foreign Study Scholarship, Rice University 2026
- Boniuk Institute, Rice University, Graduate Student Scholar 2023
- Anton and Huberte Rupert Bursary 2020
- National Research Foundation, Postgraduate Scholarship 2019
- Vice-Chancellor and Principal's Award, Faculty of Economic and Management Sciences, University of Pretoria 2019
- Dean's List, Faculty of Economic and Management Sciences, University of Pretoria 2019

Research and Professional Experience

Principal Investigator, Dissertation Fieldwork, Maua, Meru County, Kenya 2026
- Designed, piloted, and fielded an original survey of 635 women, 17 religious leaders, and 4 focus groups.

Graduate Scholar, Boniuk Institute, Rice University, Houston, TX, USA 2023 – Present
- Manage mixed-methods data collection and reporting; translate findings into policy insights with community leaders.

GIS Student Assistant, GIS/Data Center, Fondren Library, Houston, TX, USA 2023 – 2024
- Provided spatial data analysis for faculty research and taught professional development courses.

Research Assistant to Professor Matthew Clance, University of Pretoria, Pretoria, South Africa 2019 – 2021
- Built large-scale spatial and survey datasets and created an "Introduction to R" video tutorial series for students.

Conferences and Presentations

2026: Southern Economic Association (SEA) 96th Annual Meeting | Applied Microeconomics Workshop, Florida State University (invited) | ASREC Europe, Warwick Venice Centre | IRES Workshop, Chapman University | ASREC Conference, Chapman University | Economics Department Brown Bag, Rice University

2025: TEAMS Workshop, Texas A&M University | Fourth Year Conference, Rice University

2024: Third Year Conference, Rice University | Boniuk Institute Graduate Scholars Meeting, Rice University

2021: Joint Policy Workshop (Oxfam, MSF, UoN, ThinkPlace, and CHC)

Teaching Experience

Instructor, Rice University, Houston, TX, USA 2026
- Summer Math and Statistics Camp (G)

Teaching Assistant, Rice University, Houston, TX, USA 2021 – Present
- Dynamic Models for Computational Economics (UG/G), Machine Learning and Algorithms for Computational Economics (UG/G), Math for Computational Economics (UG), Macroeconomics (UG), Principles of Economics (UG)

Teaching Assistant, University of Pretoria, Pretoria, South Africa 2019 – 2021
- Econometrics (G), Microeconomics (UG), Public Economics (UG)

Professional Service

- **Referee**: *Economic Development and Cultural Change*
- **Co-Organizer**: TEAMS Workshop (2026); Rice University Development Economics Reading Group (2025 – 2026)

Technical Skills

- **Programming**: Stata, R, Python, Julia, ArcGIS, Latent Gold
- **Data Collection**: SurveyCTO, Survey Design and Sampling, Semi-structured Interviews, Focus Groups, Thematic Analysis

References

Professor Rossella Calvi (Committee Chair)
Associate Professor of Economics
Department of Economics, Rice University
Rossella.Calvi@rice.edu

Professor Isabelle Perrigne
Reginald Henry Hargrove Chair in Economics
Department of Economics, Rice University
iperrigne@gmail.com

Professor Flávio Cunha
Ervin K. Zingler Chair of Economics
Director, Center for Economic Mobility, Kinder Institute
Department of Economics, Rice University
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Professor Elaine Howard Ecklund
Herbert S. Autrey Chair in Social Sciences
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